

VIJÑĀNAVĀDA

Comprehensive Scholarly Notes — Chapter Seven

Source: C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

Covers: Introduction · Laṅkāvatārasūtra · Asaṅga · Vasubandhu · The Absolute and Its Appearances ·
Trisvabhāva · Abhūtaparikalpa · General Estimate

I. Introduction

A. Nomenclature and Identity of the School

The school goes by two names that reflect its twin commitments:

- **Vijñānavādins** — named after the doctrine that Vijñāna (Consciousness) alone is real.
- **Yogācāras** — named after the method: the practice of Yoga as the indispensable means for realising Pure Knowledge (bodhi) and traversing all ten stages (bhūmis) of Bodhisattvahood.

B. Foundational Figures and Historical Succession

Sharma traces the school's origins with careful qualification:

- **Maitreyanātha** — identified by M.M. Pt. Hara Prasad Shastri (and Profs. H. Ui and Winternitz) as the real founder. He is the teacher of Asaṅga and the first systematic expounder of Vijñānavāda.
- **Asaṅga** — conventionally credited as the founder; in reality the school's great populariser. Overshadowed Maitreyanātha by sheer philosophical brilliance.
- **Vasubandhu** — Asaṅga's younger brother. Brought the school to its zenith and is uniquely honoured as *the Second Buddha*. Converted to Vijñānavāda from the Sautrāntika school through Asaṅga's influence.
- **Pre-Asaṅga presence** — Vijñānavāda was already latent in the *Laṅkāvatāra* and in Ashvaghoṣa; Maitreyanātha systematised what was implicit there.

C. Seven Major Features of Mahāyāna (Asaṅga's Mahāyānābhīdharmaśāstra)

Asaṅga delineates Mahāyāna by seven marks:

- (1) Mahāyāna is **comprehensive** — it embraces all sentient beings, not a privileged few.
- (2) It displays **universal love** for all beings.
- (3) It takes a **wide intellectual outlook** by denying the ultimate reality of both the object (external world) and the subject (ego), admitting the reality of **Consciousness alone**.
- (4) Its ideal saint is the **Bodhisattva** — one who possesses wonderful spiritual energy specifically directed at the salvation of all beings.
- (5) It maintains that the Buddha, by his **Excellent Skilfulness (upāya-kaushalya)**, preached in accordance with the different capacities and dispositions of his audiences. No single teaching is universally binding; all are skilful adaptations.
- (6) Its final aim is **Buddhahood**, to be attained by traversing the ten stages of Bodhisattvahood.
- (7) A **Buddha can satisfy the spiritual needs of all beings** — his activity is universal, not confined to personal liberation.

D. Ten Essential Features of the Yogācāra School (Asaṅga's Mahāyānasamparigraha-śāstra)

Asaṅga provides ten defining doctrinal commitments of the Yogācāra:

- (1) The **Ālayavijñāna is immanent in all beings** — the Store-house Consciousness is the universal ground pervading all sentient existence.
- (2) There are **three kinds of knowledge**: illusory (parikalpita), relative (paratantra), and absolute (pariniṣpanna).
- (3) The **objective world and the subjective ego are only manifestations** of Universal Consciousness (Ālaya) — neither has independent ontological status.
- (4) The **Six Perfections (Pāramitās)** are emphasised as the path of the Bodhisattva.
- (5) Buddhahood requires passing through the **ten stages of Bodhisattvahood** — the bhūmis constitute the graduated path to enlightenment.
- (6) Mahāyāna is **far superior to Hīnayāna**, which is characterised as individualistic, selfish, narrow, and as having fundamentally misunderstood Buddha's teaching.
- (7) The goal is to become **one, through Bodhi, with the Dharmakāya** — Buddha's Body of Pure Existence.
- (8) The **subject-object duality must be transcended** and unity with Pure Consciousness attained.
- (9) From the ultimate standpoint, there is **absolutely no difference between Saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa**. Nirvāṇa is to be realised here and now by embracing 'Sameness' (samatva) and discarding 'Plurality' (nānātva).
- (10) **Reality is Dharmakāya** — Buddha's Body of Pure Existence — which is simultaneously Pure Consciousness and which manifests: (a) from Saṃsāra's viewpoint as **Nirmāṇakāya** (Body of Becoming), and (b) from Nirvāṇa's viewpoint as **Sambhogakāya** (Body of Bliss).

II. The Laṅkāvatārasūtra

A. Foundational Doctrine: Consciousness-Only (Vijñaptimātra)

The Laṅkāvatāra aligns with Ashvagoṣa's identification of Tathatā with Bodhi or Ālayavijñāna, and of the latter with Tathāgatagarbha. Its central metaphysical claim:

All dharmas, except Consciousness, are **unreal**. Consciousness-only (vijñaptimātra) is the established truth preached by the Buddha. All three worlds (kāma, rūpa, and arūpa — i.e., of Matter, Form, and No-form) are the result of discrimination (vikalpa) or thought-relations. No external object exists in reality. All that is, is Consciousness.

The apparent support for crude Subjectivism in the text is misleading — its deeper expressions forbid drawing that conclusion.

B. The Architecture of Consciousness

The text draws a fundamental distinction between two orders of consciousness, then maps individual experience within them:

- **Absolute Consciousness (Ālaya-vijñāna / Tathāgatagarbha)** — the source from which the external world is created. Crucially: it is the *Absolute* consciousness, not the individual mind (manas, chitta, or vijñāna), that creates. The confusion in the Laṅkāvatāra arises from loose use of the terms 'Manas', 'Chitta', and 'Vijñāna'.
- **Individual Consciousness (pravṛtti-vijñāna)** — further divided into seven vijñānas:

- The five sense-cognitions (chakṣu, ghrāṇa, shrotra, jihvā, kāya-vijñānas) recognised by the Sarvāstivādins.
- Manovijñāna — the sixth, or normal conceptual consciousness.
- Kṛṣṭa-manovijñāna — a seventh, 'Continuous Consciousness', added by the Yogācāras. It functions as an *intermediary* between the sixth Manovijñāna and the Ālaya itself.

The epistemic roles are precisely distributed:

- By the **first five vijñānas**: an object is *sensed*.
- By **Manovijñāna (sixth)**: it is *thought*.
- By **Manas / Kṛṣṭa-manovijñāna (seventh)**: it is *perceived* (in the deeper, continuous sense).
- Underlying all: the '**synthetic unity of apperception**' called **Chitta (Ālaya)** — the ultimate background of cognitive activity.

C. The Ālayavijñāna in the Laṅkāvatāra: Permanent, Immortal, Never-Changing

This is a philosophically pivotal point that Sharma emphasises against the conventional reading:

Contrary to the general belief that Ālayavijñāna is an ever-changing stream, the Laṅkāvatāra declares it to be a **permanent, immortal, and never-changing store-house of Consciousness** underlying the apparent subject-object duality.

The Ālaya's specific characteristics as stated in the Laṅkāvatāra:

- It **transcends subject-object duality** (grāhya-grāhakavisaṃyukta).
- It is **beyond production, existence, and destruction** (utpāda-sthiti-bhaṅgavarjya).
- It is **beyond all plurality of imagination** (vikalpa-prapañcha-rahita).
- It is to be **directly realised by Pure Knowledge** (nirābhāsa-prajñā-gochara).

The **force behind creation** is beginningless Ignorance operative within the Ālaya, causing it to manifest as subject and object. Both the locus (āśraya) and the object (viśaya) of this tendency are the Ālaya itself. Creation = the result of beginningless Ignorance leading to plurality (anādikāla-prapañcha-dauṣṭhulyavāsanā).

D. Relation Between the Ālaya and Individual Vijñānas: The Ocean-Wave Analogy

Individual Pravṛtti-vijñānas are manifestations of the Ālaya. Their ontological relation is specified with precision:

They are **neither identical with nor different from** the Ālaya. If identical, their cessation would entail the Ālaya's cessation. If different, they could not arise out of it. → The Ālaya is the ocean; Pravṛtti-vijñānas are the waves stirred by the wind of objects (which are themselves creations of Ignorance). Just as waves are neither identical with nor different from the ocean, so the individual vijñānas are neither identical with nor different from the Absolute Chitta or Ālaya.

Ultimately, the Ālaya **transcends all categories of intellect** and is Indescribable — the ocean/wave comparison is itself a concession to discursive thought.

E. Ālaya as Tathāgatagarbha: Proximity to Ātman and the Buddhist Distinction

The Laṅkāvatāra calls the Ālaya by yet another name — **Tathāgata-garbha** (Womb of the Tathāgata) — and attributes to it qualities that bring it very close to the Brahmanical Ātman:

- It is **intrinsically shining / self-luminous** (prakṛti-prabhāsvara).
- It is **absolutely pure** (ādi-vishuddha).
- It is **immanent in all beings** (sarvasattva-dehāntar-gata).
- It is **immortal, permanent (nitya, dhruva), and blissful (shiva)**.

The text itself raises the problem: Mahāmāti asks Bhagavān — if Tathāgatagarbha has all these qualities, is it not similar to the Ātman of the Non-Buddhists (Tīrthikas)?

Bhagavān's reply (the Buddhist distinction):

- No — the Tathāgatagarbha is NOT similar to the Ātman because:
 - It **transcends all categories of finite thought (nirvikalpa)** — it is neither affirmation nor negation nor both nor neither.
 - It is to be **directly realised by Spiritual Experience (nirābhāsa-gochra)**.
 - The Ātman of the Non-Buddhists **leads to Eternalism** because it clings to affirmation. The Tathāgatagarbha avoids this trap.

Sharma's critical observation: Bhagavān of the Laṅkāvatāra conveniently forgets that the Ātman of the Upaniṣads — from which the Tathāgatagarbha is derived — is *also* Nirvikalpa and Nirābhāsaprajñā-gochara. The distinction is more formal than substantive.

III. Asaṅga

A. Critique of Relational Intellect (Tarka)

In the *Mahāyāna-Sūtrālaṅkāra-Śāstra* (likely the work of Maitreya-nātha with Asaṅga's commentary — per Profs. Levi, Ui, and Winternitz — though Sharma agrees with Levi that the Kārikā and Commentary belong to Asaṅga), Asaṅga mounts a thoroughgoing critique of relational intellect:

- Intellect (tarka) is **based on Religious Texts (āgama-nishrita)** — thus it is only provisional (niyata), not final. What is true today may be found untrue tomorrow; what is true for some may be untrue for others.
- It is **partial (avyāpi)**, not all-pervasive or omniscient — it cannot know everything.
- It is **phenomenal, not real (sāmvṛta)** — it operates in the domain of appearance.
- It leads to **dissatisfaction, woeful discussions, insoluble antinomies, and misery** — 'Knowledge increaseth sorrow' (khedavān).
- Only the unwise cling to it (bālāshraya). It **cannot give us Reality**.

B. The Doctrine of Universal Momentariness (Extended to Phenomena)

Asaṅga argues that every phenomenal thing, being relative (dependent on causes and conditions), is necessarily momentary:

- **Causal argument:** Everything that arises out of causes and conditions is necessarily momentary. If it were not momentary, it would not come into existence at all — the preceding moment is the cause of the succeeding moment.
- **Persistence argument:** If a thing were permanent, how could it afterwards cease to exist?
- **Self-permanence impossibility:** A thing cannot become permanent by itself because afterwards it ceases to exist.
- **External permanence impossibility:** If it is not permanent by itself, it cannot be made permanent by anything else either. Change is the fundamental law of the universe.
- **Scriptural testimony:** Yogis realise through scripture that Saṃskāras come into existence and cease every moment.
- **Illustrative analogies:** River water is always flowing — fresh waters come in every moment. In a lamp, one flame continually succeeds another. Nothing in the world is non-momentary.

External objects do not exist outside of thought. The empirical ego is also unreal.

Critical qualification: Momentariness applies *only* to the phenomenal. It does not even touch Reality, which is above all categories. This is the crucial limit of the doctrine that Sharma emphasises.

C. The Unreality of the Empirical Self (Ego)

The Vijñānavādins — both Asaṅga and Vasubandhu — deny the ultimate reality of the empirical self or ego:

- All miseries and sufferings arise from the **false notion of 'I' and 'Mine'**.
- If the self does not really exist, it cannot be taken as a seer, knower, doer, or enjoyer.
- When Buddha preached the existence of the self, it was only a **pedagogical device** — to attract the simple-minded and encourage good deeds. In reality, there is no ego.
- **Dilemma argument:** If an ego really existed, there would be either liberation without effort (since the self already exists pure) or no liberation at all (since an existent self would be unremovable). Both consequences are unacceptable.
- The notion of the ego is due to **beginningless Ignorance** which must be overcome.

Critical distinction: It is ONLY the empirical self / individual ego that is declared unreal. Pure Consciousness or the Universal Self is not only admitted but declared **the only Reality**. By its very nature it is Self-luminous; all impurities are adventitious (āgantuka).

D. The Nature of the Real (Non-Dual Absolute)

Asaṅga's characterisation of the Real through a systematic via negativa:

- Neither existence nor non-existence
- Neither affirmation nor negation
- Neither identity nor difference
- Neither one nor many
- Neither increasing nor decreasing
- Neither pure nor impure
- Neither production nor destruction

- It is **beyond Ignorance and beyond intellect**

The ego is neither real nor unreal nor both — it is only an **illusion (bhrama)**. Liberation = the destruction of illusion or ignorance (bhrama/avidyā), not the destruction of any real entity.

E. The Path to Liberation in Asaṅga

Asaṅga's path involves a progressive negation of layers of appearance:

- Stage 1 — A **Bodhisattva first realises** that external objects are only imaginary and that mind alone exists.
- Stage 2 — He then realises that **individual mind too is as much an imagination** as any external object.
- Stage 3 — Having shaken off all duality, he **directly perceives the Absolute**, the unity underlying phenomena (dharmadhātu).

The Supreme Reality, when all categories merge in it, **removes all the defects of the intellect** just as a strong medicine removes poison. By becoming one with Reality, a Bodhisattva realises the Last Meditation (chaturtha-dhyāna — like turīya) and ever dwells in the Blissful Brahman.

He is then fully qualified to work for the real emancipation of humanity — like a bird that, having developed full wings, becomes able to soar high.

The vessel-moon analogy: When a vessel containing water is broken, the moon's reflection is no longer visible in it. Similarly, in impure persons the reflection of the Buddha is not visible. But knowing the unreality of ego and dharmas and realising Reality as non-dual, a wise man embraces it as Pure Consciousness. Even this recognition will ultimately be transcended — Liberation is that **indescribable state where all cries of intellect are satisfied and all categories merged**.

Buddha has never taught the Doctrine by speech — it is to be directly realised by Pure Consciousness. Every phenomenon is merged in the harmonious bosom of Reality.

The river-ocean analogy: Different rivers flowing through different places are called 'rivers'; when they merge in the ocean they become one with it and are 'the ocean'. Similarly, individual intellects (holding different views) become one with the Buddha/Absolute — they *are* the Absolute.

Setting on the right path — understanding Nairātmya (no-self) and grasping the real meaning of Śūnyatā — the Enlightened Ones transcend individual existence, realise the Pure Soul (shuddhātman), and become one with that Universal Soul (Paramātman). This is the Pure Existence of the Buddha, the Highest Soul (paramātman). The Yogācāras stress the importance of Vihāras and Bhūmis which purify a Bodhisattva and by which discursive intellect is transformed into Spiritual Experience.

IV. Vasubandhu: Absolutism of Pure Consciousness

A. Vasubandhu's Intellectual Trajectory

- Originally belonged to the **Sautrāntika School**, writing his Abhidharmakosha following the Kāshmīra-Vaibhāṣika branch of the Sarvāstivāda School of Hīnayāna.
- Even in the Abhidharmakosha, the influence of Mahāyāna is already visible — 'Abhidharma' is identified with Pure Knowledge together with its means.
- In the Kosha, the phenomenal is like 'water in a jar', the Absolute like 'the vast ocean'. Intellect is transcended in the last Meditation where the meditator becomes one with the Real. This Pure Knowledge is called Shrāmaṇya as well as Brāhmaṇya.
- Later **converted to Vijñānavāda** by his elder brother Asaṅga.

B. The Vijñapti-Mātratā-Siddhi: Viṃśatikā — Proof that Reality is Pure Consciousness

Vasubandhu's primary aim: to prove that Reality is Pure Consciousness and that external objects do not exist outside thought. He does this by **refuting the objections of opponents** systematically.

1. The Basic Idealist Claim

In Mahāyāna, the Viṃśatikā asserts: all three worlds do not exist outside thought. Mind, thought, consciousness, knowledge are synonyms. External objects depend on thought like the hair seen floating in the atmosphere or like the perception of the double-moon.

2. The Opponent's Four Objections

The realist opponent urges that if external objects do not exist, we cannot account for four phenomena:

- **Desha-niyama (spatial determination)**: An object is seen in a particular place and not everywhere. How can this be explained if representations arise without external sense-objects?
- **Kāla-niyama (temporal determination)**: An object is seen at a particular time and not at all times. Without an external object anchoring experience, temporal specificity is inexplicable.
- **Santānāniyama (indetermination of the perceiving stream of consciousness)**: All persons present at a given place and time — not one person only — perceive that particular object. This intersubjective agreement points to an external reality.
- **Kṛtya-kriyā (fruitful activity)**: Things like food, water, cloth, poison, weapons etc. seen in a dream are purely imaginary and devoid of activity (a dream-dagger cannot kill). This shows that real food and water — unlike dream-objects — can satisfy hunger and thirst. Therefore external objects must exist.

3. Vasubandhu's Replies to Each Objection

General counter-principle: These four phenomena do not justify the independent existence of external objects because they are found even in dreams and in hell, where there are no external objects.

Reply to spatial and temporal determination (Objections 1 & 2):

- Even in a dream, things like a city, a garden, a woman, a man etc. are seen in a particular place and at a particular time — not in all places and at all times. Spatial and temporal

specificity are therefore consistent with the absence of external objects.

Reply to intersubjective agreement (Objection 3):

- All those persons who, on account of their bad deeds, go to hell see the same river of pus etc. — all of them, not one only. Thus indetermination of the stream of consciousness (intersubjective agreement) occurs in hell without any external objects. The infernal guards themselves cannot be real because they do not suffer the agony of hell. The opponent grants that infernal guards are produced by the force of the deeds of those who go to hell. But the impression (vāsanā) of the deed is *in consciousness*, while its result is wrongly imagined to be outside consciousness. The impression as well as the result of the deed must both be in consciousness itself. **Hence consciousness is the only reality.**

Reply to fruitful activity (Objection 4):

- Fruitful activity too results from unreal dream-objects. The roaring of a dream-tiger causes real fear and disturbs sleep. An erotic dream is followed by consequences which are physically real. Therefore fruitful activity does not require external objects.

4. Consciousness Manifesting as Subject and Object

Consciousness arises out of its own seed (svabīja) and then manifests itself as an external object. Therefore Buddha said there are two bases of cognition — internal and external. By knowing this, one realises:

- There is no personal ego (both subject and object are manifestations of consciousness).
- There are no external objects (they too are manifestations of consciousness).

5. Pure Consciousness: Beyond Intellect, Directly Realised

The Indescribable Pure Consciousness which is to be directly realised by the Buddhas can never be denied. It cannot be conceived by intellect:

- The idea of Pure Consciousness as conceived by finite thought through the category of 'existence' is itself unreal — if it were real, the conceptions of intellect would be real, which would undermine the doctrine that Pure Consciousness alone exists.
- Pure Consciousness cannot be grasped by intellect as an object. **But this does not mean Pure Consciousness in itself does not exist.** It can be directly realised by Spiritual Experience which transcends the subject-object duality.

6. Vasubandhu's Refutation of Perception as Proof

- Perception cannot guarantee the existence of external objects because the awareness is the **same even in dreams and in the perception of the double-moon.**
- Memory does not imply the perception of an external object — only its consciousness.

7. The Dream-Waking Analogy: Objection and Reply

Opponent: If there is no difference between dreaming and waking states, we should know even when fully awake that external objects do not exist, just as we know dream-objects are unreal.

Vasubandhu: Before we are fully awake we cannot know that dream-objects are unreal. Things seen in a dream are as real to the dreamer as any object is to us in waking. It is only when we are awake that we realise the unreality of dream-objects. Similarly, worldly people are **slumbering in ignorance**. They do not realise, as long as they are under the infatuation of ignorance, that

this world does not really exist. It is only when true knowledge dawns that Reality — Pure Consciousness — can be realised.

Intellect inevitably involves itself in dualism. Unless the subject-object duality is transcended, we cannot realise Reality.

Conclusion of the Viṃśatikā: Reality is Pure Consciousness. But as this Reality is beyond discursive intellect, it cannot be fully grasped by it. It can only be realised by transcending the subject-object duality, by going beyond all the categories of intellect, by embracing Pure Consciousness — in short, by becoming a Buddha.

V. The Absolute and Its Appearances (Triṃśikā / Sthiramati's Commentary)

A. The Aim of the Triṃśikā (Sthiramati's Commentary)

Sthiramati, commentator on the Triṃśikā, states that Vasubandhu's aim is twofold:

- To show the real meaning of the ultimate unreality of the subject — **pudgala-nairātmya**.
- To show the real meaning of the ultimate unreality of the object — **dharma-nairātmya**.

There are two kinds of Ignorance:

- **Kleshāvaraṇa**: Due to the false notion of the reality of the individual subject; leads to all sorts of suffering.
- **Jñeyāvaraṇa**: Due to the false notion of the reality of external objects; screens the real nature of objects.

To destroy these two kinds of Ignorance is the aim of the Triṃśikā. An additional aim: to demolish two **extreme views (ekāntavāda)**:

- That external objects, like consciousness, are absolutely real.
- That consciousness, like external objects, is only relative and therefore unreal.

B. The Śūnyavāda-Vijñānavāda Agreement on Consciousness

Some scholars maintain that Śūnyavāda declares even consciousness to be unreal. Sharma argues this is incorrect:

- It is only the **individual subject** which is declared unreal by Śūnyavāda. Vijñānavāda agrees here.
- Śūnyavāda criticises **self-consciousness** (consciousness of consciousness) — fire cannot burn itself, the edge of a sword cannot cut itself, the tip of a finger cannot touch itself; consciousness of consciousness leads to infinite regress.
- But Śūnyavāda maintains the reality of **Pure Consciousness**. Nāgārjuna identifies his Prapañcha-Śūnya Tattva with Bodhi or Prajñā. The Bodhi of Nāgārjuna, the Chitta of Āryadeva, and the Bodhi-Chitta of Shāntideva are the Self-luminous Self which is the Absolute.

C. The Three Modifications (Tridhā Pariṇāma) of Reality

The Trīṃśikā declares: Reality (Vijñaptimātra) on account of its inherent power (shakti) suffers threefold modification:

Modification 1: Ālayavijñāna (Vipāka)

- Reality first manifests as **Ālayavijñāna** — also called Vipāka (Store-house Consciousness).
- The seeds of **all phenomena are present** in it.
- It is a **continually changing stream** of consciousness like a stream of water (vartate srotasaughavat, K. 4).
- When Buddhahood is realised, its flow at once comes to an end (tasya vyāvṛtitarhatve, K. 5).

Modification 2: Klišṭa Manovijñāna (Individual Self / Ego)

- The **individual self (klišṭa manovijñāna)** depends on the Ālaya.
- It is accompanied by four kinds of suffering: **self-notion, self-delusion, self-pride, and self-love**.
- It ceases to function when the false notion of the ego is destroyed and the categories of intellect are transcended.

Modification 3: Six Vijñānas / Manovijñāna and Viśaya-vijñāna

- The third modification is the form of the **objects and mental states** — the six Vijñānas (ṣaḍvidha), comprising the mental states (manovijñāna) and the so-called external objects (viśaya-vijñāna).
- These are of two kinds: **pure (kushala) and impure (akushala)**, accompanied by various sufferings (klesha) and sub-sufferings (upaklesha).
- These Vijñānas stand in the same relation to the Ālaya as **waves stand to water** (taraṅgāṇām yathā jale, K. 15).

Thus: subject and object are only modifications of the Ālaya, which is itself only a modification of Pure Consciousness. Hence it is established that **Pure Consciousness is the only Reality**.

D. Ālaya of the Laṅkāvatāra vs. Ālaya of Vasubandhu — A Key Distinction

Sharma draws a precise technical distinction:

- **Ālayavijñāna of the Laṅkāvatāra**: Identified with Tathāgatagarbha / Pure Chitta — this is Pure Consciousness, the permanent background of all phenomena, transcending subject-object duality. It is identical with Vasubandhu's **Vijñaptimātra**.
- **Ālayavijñāna of Vasubandhu**: Only a *phenomenal manifestation* of Pure Consciousness. It is the Store-house containing seeds of all phenomena (sarva-bījakam, K. 2). It is a continually changing stream (srotasaughavat). When Buddhahood is achieved it ceases. It is 'Santati-nitya' (relatively permanent), not absolutely permanent.

The phenomenal Ālaya of Vasubandhu contains the seeds of all phenomena (subjective and objective). The individual self depends on it; the six vijñānas are its waves. But behind all this modification stands the **permanent, eternal, unchanging Pure Consciousness (Vijñaptimātra)**.

VI. Trisvabhāva: The Three Natures / Levels of Existence

A. Correspondence with Śūnyavāda Categories

Vijñānavāda maps the Śūnyavāda's two categories onto three:

- Śūnyavāda's **Paramārtha** → Vijñānavāda's **Pariniṣpanna** (the Absolutely Real).
- Śūnyavāda's **Samvṛti** is split into:
 - **Paratantra** (the Relative/Dependent) — what Śūnyavāda's Samvṛti contains that has causal conditionality.
 - **Parikalpita** (the Imaginary/Illusory) — what Śūnyavāda's Samvṛti contains that is purely superimposed.

B. The Three Svabhāvas Defined

1. Parikalpita (the Imaginary):

- Purely imaginary — like a hare's horn, a barren woman's child, a sky-flower, a dream, a mirage, the perception of double-moon.
- It is a **mere name (nāma or jalpa)** according to Asaṅga.
- Maitreya-nātha: absolutely unreal (atyanta-śūnya).
- It is the unreal subject-object duality superimposed (abhūtaś chāsau parikalpitaḥ).
- All individual subjects and all objects in all three worlds are declared Parikalpita.

2. Paratantra (the Relative):

- Based on discursive intellect, dependent on causes and conditions, comes under the realm of the phenomenal.
- Like an error (bhrānti) according to Asaṅga — it is an appearance (tasmin na tadbhāvaḥ), conditional/phenomenal (samvṛti), infected with the subject-object duality (grāhyagrāhaka-lakṣaṇa).
- Maitreya-nātha: relative, based on intellect (laukikagochara).
- Both the imaginary and the relative are **indescribable** — they can be described as neither existent nor non-existent. Not existent because they do not exist in fact; not non-existent because they exist as an illusion or appearance.
- The relative arises out of causes and conditions (Vasubandhu).
- Its support is the **immanent Ālaya** — relative reality (paratantra).

3. Pariniṣpanna (the Absolute):

- The Paramārtha, the absolutely real, based on spiritual experience which transcends subject-object duality and the plurality of phenomena.
- Various called: **Tathatā, Tathāgatagarbha, Ālayavijñāna (in the Laṅkāvatāra sense), Āryajñāna, Samyagjñāna, or Prajñā.**
- Maitreya-nātha: the absolutely real based on direct realisation (avikalpa-jñāna-gochara).
- Vasubandhu: exists **independently in itself and by itself.**
- Devoid of thought-constructions (niṣsvabhāva) because it cannot be grasped by any category of the intellect — though it exists independently and can be directly realised through spiritual experience.

- The Transcendental Ground-Reality where the Ālaya is shorn of all its adventitious characters and thus transcended (āshrayaparāvṛtti) — this is the absolute Reality (pariniṣpanna).

C. The Three Nissvabhāvas (Three Senses of 'Devoid of Own-Nature')

All three aspects are Nissvabhāva, but in different senses:

- **Parikalpita is Nissvabhāva** because it is absolutely unreal — though it exists as a name or illusion.
- **Paratantra is Nissvabhāva** because it does not ultimately exist independently — though it exists as an appearance.
- **Pariniṣpanna is Nissvabhāva** because it cannot be grasped by any category of the intellect — though it exists independently and by itself and can be directly realised through spiritual experience.

D. Liberation through Realising the Three Natures

When the unreality of external objects is realised, the individual subject also becomes unreal — subject and object are correlative; one cannot exist without the other. When subject-object duality is transcended, one dwells in the harmonious bosom of the Absolute.

As long as individual consciousness does not realise its essential unity with Pure Consciousness, the intellect goes on giving rise to the subject-object duality. Ultimately even the sentence 'Reality is Pure Consciousness' is also unreal — it is an expression of the intellect itself.

VII. Abhūtaparikalpa

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/1ZSR5FHcdcxz1Y3qMuig5DHMoEwtzTNG/view?usp=sharing>

A. Correcting Nihilistic Misreadings of Śūnyatā

The Vijñānavādin — like the Śūnyavādin — warns against a nihilistic misconception of Śūnyatā:

- Śūnyatā is **not absolute negation** — it is the negation of something *in* something.
- Only the superimposed (parikalpita) can be negated.
- That which is negated is unreal; but that which is the **supporting ground of superimposition is real**.
- Pure Consciousness, as the transcendental background of all phenomena, is the only Reality; the superimposed phenomena are all unreal.

The difference between Vijñānavādin and Śūnyavādin here is **one of degree, not kind**. The Vijñānavādin has given a clear and detailed account of that which the Śūnyavādin left more or less implicit. This is one of the chief merits of Vijñānavāda — it has cleared the misunderstandings and left no scope for nihilistic misconceptions about Śūnyatā.

B. The Concept of Abhūtaparikalpa: Triple Application

Abhūtaparikalpa applies to all three svabhāvas but in different senses — just as Śūnyatā applies to both phenomena and noumenon:

When applied to the Absolute (Pariniṣpanna):

- Abhūtaparikalpa means '**the Real Transcendent Ground of all superimposed phenomena**' (abhūtasya parikalpo yasmin saḥ) — it is the ground in which superimposition takes place, but which itself does not involve itself in superimposition. It only allows itself to be *indirectly* superimposed upon.

When applied to the Relative (Paratantra):

- Abhūtaparikalpa means '**the phenomenal world of subject-object duality manifested by the self-creative energy of the Ālaya**' (abhūtasya parikalpo yasmāt saḥ) — the Constructive Consciousness.
- The term 'abhūtaparikalpa' is usually used for **Ālayavijñāna (Constructive Consciousness)**, also known as the āshraya or the immanent supporting ground of all phenomena.
- It is the dynamic stream of Constructive Consciousness which manifests itself, through its own power of beginningless and transcendental Ignorance, as the phenomenal world of subject-object duality.
- Also called **vikalpa** (thought-constructing energy) and **paratantra** (conditioned by causation; relative).
- Identified with its contents, it is relative; viewed in its own essence, it is the Absolute. The Absolute is at once immanent in phenomena and transcendent to them.

When applied to the Imaginary (Parikalpita):

- Abhūtaparikalpa means '**the unreal subject-object duality which is superimposed**' (abhūtash chāsau parikalpitaḥ).
- All individual subjects and objects in all three worlds are imaginary (parikalpita).

The abhūtaparikalpa, as Ālaya, is relative — it is the connecting link between the Real and the unreal. Its essence is the Real; its contents are unreal.

C. The Absolute Described (Triṃśikā, K. 29-30)

Pure Consciousness transcends the intellect and all its categories as well as the plurality of the phenomenal world. It is characterised as:

- **Anāsravo dhātuḥ** — Pure and Undefined Existence
- **Achintyaḥ** — beyond finite thought
- **Kushalaḥ** — the Good
- **Dhruvaḥ** — the Eternal
- **Sukhaḥ** — the Blissful
- **Vimuktiḥ** — Liberation itself
- **Dharmakāya** — Buddha's Body of Pure Existence

VIII. General Estimate

A. The Standard Misreadings of Vijñānavāda (Refuted by Sharma)

It is generally believed that Vijñānavāda is a crude Subjectivism which:

- Denies the reality of external objects and takes them as projections of the momentary Vijñānas.
- Denies the existence of the Self.
- Maintains nothing over and above momentary ideas.
- Maintains the doctrine of constant flux.
- Holds that Reality is only the individual momentary Vijñāna.

Sharma declares: our exposition of Vijñānavāda deals a death-blow to all such false notions. In no standard work of the Vijñānavāda do we find any of these doctrines. It is a great irony of fate that Śūnyavāda should be condemned as Nihilism and that Vijñānavāda — which is Absolute Idealism — should be condemned as Subjectivism advocating the doctrine of Universal Flux.

B. The True Scope of Momentariness

- Momentariness is restricted by Vijñānavāda to **phenomena only**.
- In the phenomenal sphere it is emphasised. But momentariness does **not even touch Reality**.
- Reality truly speaking transcends all the categories of the intellect. It is **neither momentary nor permanent**.
- But from the phenomenal point of view it must be described as the **eternal, immortal, and permanent background** of all momentary phenomena.

C. The True Scope of Self-Denial

- It is only the empirical self / individual subject / Ego that is declared unreal by Vijñānavāda.
- The reality of **Pure Consciousness alone** — variously called Ālayavijñāna (Laṅkāvatāra), Tathāgatagarbha, Chittamātra, Vijñaptimātra — is emphatically maintained.
- Pure Consciousness transcends the dualism of subject and object as well as the plurality of phenomena. It is the same as the Self-luminous Self.

D. Vijñānavāda is NOT Subjectivism

- It is not the individual consciousness (kliṣṭa manovijñāna) as associated with other momentary functional ideas (pravṛttivijñāna) that creates the external world.
- The external world is declared to be a manifestation or modification of **Absolute Consciousness**.
- When the external world is declared unreal, what is meant is that it does **not exist independently and outside of Consciousness** — not that it does not appear to exist.
- The **objectivity of the external world is not denied**. Objects appear as objects to the subject which perceives them. Only their objectivity does not fall outside of Consciousness because the distinction of subject and object is *within* Consciousness itself, which ultimately transcends the subject-object duality.
- Consciousness is immanent in all phenomena and it is also the permanent transcendental background of all phenomena.

E. The Debate on Permanence: Bhattacharya vs. Sharma

MM. Pt. Vidhushekhara Bhattacharya raises an interesting point:

- He argues that the Pure Consciousness of Vasubandhu is not absolutely permanent (kūṭastha-nitya) but only relatively permanent (āpekṣika-nitya).
- He distinguishes 'absolutely permanent' (Nitya) from 'relatively permanent' (Dhruva). He claims Vasubandhu uses 'Dhruva' (not 'Nitya') in Triṃśikā K. 30 — therefore Vijñaptimātra is only relatively permanent, like a stream or a flame (Prāvāhanitya / Santatinitya).

Sharma's two-part response:

- **Concession:** Pt. Bhattacharya is perfectly right that the *Ālayavijñāna* of Vasubandhu is relatively permanent — Vasubandhu himself makes it clear that the *Ālaya* is only a phenomenal manifestation of Pure Consciousness and is like a stream (srotasaughavat). It may be rightly called 'Santati-nitya'.
- **Refutation:** But Bhattacharya fails to distinguish the *Ālayavijñāna* of Vasubandhu from his Vijñaptimātra. He is certainly wrong in saying that the Vijñaptimātra is also relatively permanent.
- The distinction between Nitya and Dhruva is not absolute — these words are often used as synonyms by Buddhism and Vedānta alike. 'Dhruva', 'Nitya', 'Ajara', 'Amara', 'Shāshvata', 'Kūṭastha' are often used interchangeably.
- Vasubandhu uses 'Dhruva' here in the sense of the absolutely permanent.
- **Sthiramati's testimony** (decisive): Sthiramati, the commentator on Vasubandhu, while explaining the Kārikā in which Vijñaptimātra is declared to be 'Dhruva', clearly points out that the word 'Dhruva' means 'Nitya' (eternal). He says: Vijñaptimātra is eternal and permanent; it is blissful because it is permanent — for what is permanent is bliss and what is momentary is misery (dhruvo nityatvād akṣayatayā, sukho nityatvād eva; yadanityam tad duḥkham, Triṃśikā-Bhāṣya, p. 44).

F. Vasubandhu's System as Absolute Idealism: Vedāntic Parallels

Sharma concludes by drawing the systematic parallel between Vasubandhu's Vijñānavāda and Advaita Vedānta:

Vijñānavāda Concept → Advaita Vedānta Equivalent

- **Vijñaptimātra** (Pure Consciousness, the absolute) → **Brahman / Ātman**
- **Ālayavijñāna** (phenomenal manifestation of Pure Consciousness, seed-ground) → **Īshvara**
- **Kliṣṭa Manovijñāna** (individual ego / false self) → **Jīva**
- **Viśayavijñapti** (the so-called external objects / phenomenal world) → **Jagat**
- **Pariṇāma** (the transformation/modification process in Vijñānavāda) → **Vivarta** (the illusory appearance in Vedānta)

Vasubandhu's system, therefore, is **Absolute Idealism**. The correspondences with Advaita Vedānta are not coincidental — both systems converge on the insight that Absolute Consciousness (whether named Vijñaptimātra or Brahman) is the sole ultimate Reality, that the individual ego and the phenomenal world are modifications or illusory appearances of that one Reality, and that liberation consists in the direct experiential realisation of this identity, which transcends all conceptual mediation.

End of Chapter Seven Notes — Vijñānavāda

Source: C. D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapter 7, pp. 108–123